ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

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THA 131: Basic Theatre Design and Crafts - Scenery, Lighting and Models

From a director's idea to a buildable, budgeted design

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Design is a set of constraints solved creatively: text, space, budget, labour and safety. This pack covers design elements and principles, ground plans and models, materials and construction basics, lighting and sound roles, and how to present a design to a production team.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Apply the elements and principles of design to a script's requirements.
- Produce a ground plan and a scale model for a short scene.
- Identify common scenery, lighting and sound equipment and their functions.
- Present a design with a budget and a build schedule.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Elements and principles

Design language is learnable and assessable.

- Elements: line, shape, form, colour, texture and space.
- Principles: contrast, rhythm, unity, emphasis, pattern, movement, balance and scale.
- Start from the text: period, location, tone, entrances and required levels.
- Design for the audience's sightlines, not for a photograph.
- Every element should be justified by the production concept.
- A design that cannot be built within budget and time is not finished.

Drawings, models and materials

Technical communication prevents expensive mistakes.

- Ground plan: viewed from above, to scale, with all entrances and furniture positions.
- Elevation and section: show heights and construction.
- Model: white card or foam board at 1:25 or 1:50, with a human figure for scale.
- Timber, plywood, canvas, steel and fabric each impose different construction rules.
- Paint and finish affect how lighting reads on stage.
- Label everything and include a materials list.

> **Safety is part of design**
> A platform that flexes, a rail that wobbles or a cable across a walkway is a failed design regardless of how it looks.

Lighting, sound and presentation

Design is a collaborative department, not a solo artwork.

- Lighting shapes visibility, focus, mood and time of day.
- Common units: profile and fresnel lanterns, LED fixtures, dimmers and a control desk.
- Colour temperature and gels change how costume and paint read.
- Sound design covers reinforcement, effects and cues; know the difference between live and recorded sources.
- Present the concept, ground plan, model, materials list and budget on one board.
- Walk the production team through the design in five minutes without reading from notes.

From script to ground plan

A designer reads a script for spatial demands, not for adjectives. Underline every entrance and exit, every level change, every object a character uses, and every line that fixes a location. That list is the brief. A design that ignores an exit will be redrawn during the build, which is expensive and embarrassing.

The ground plan is the first tool: a scale drawing of the stage seen from above, showing the set footprint, furniture positions, entrances and the auditorium edge. It is drawn at a stated scale, usually 1:25 or 1:50, and every element is labelled. The director uses it to block; the builder uses it to cut; the lighting designer uses it to place positions.

Elevations and sections come next, showing heights and construction. A section drawing is what reveals a problem the plan hides: a platform that blocks sightlines from the side seats, or a doorway too narrow for a costume to pass through.

Lighting, sound and the design team

Lighting does four jobs: it makes performers visible, it focuses attention, it establishes mood and time, and it separates areas of the stage. Learn the common instruments and what each does - a profile lantern throws a controllable, hard-edged beam for specials and gobos; a fresnel gives a soft, adjustable wash; LED fixtures mix colour without gels but behave differently on camera.

Colour behaves differently under different sources. A costume that reads warm red in daylight may go muddy under a saturated blue wash, and a painted flat under tungsten looks different from the same flat under a cold LED. This is why designers test under the actual plot rather than choosing colours from a swatch book.

Sound design covers reinforcement (making voices audible), effects (creating place and event) and music. Establish early whether effects are live or recorded and who cues them. A sound cue late by two seconds is a visible mistake in a way that a slightly different shade of paint is not.

> **Design is a budget document**
> A concept without a materials list, a cost and a build schedule is a drawing. Present all three or the design is not finished.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 131

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 131 Basic Theatre Design and Crafts: fundamentals of scene, sound, lighting, costume, make-up and masks
- Drawing, altering and repairing designs, accessories, building, painting, fitting, decorating and budgeting
- THA 132 Trends in Theatre Design and Technologies listed as the companion course

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 131 Basic Theatre Design and Crafts, 3 credits, first semester
- THA 233 Design Concepts in Performance Spaces and THA 343 Set and Lighting Design appear at 200 and 300 level
- Design sequence spans all four years in this listing

What changed: The 2019 listing adds THA 233 and THA 343, formalising the design sequence that the 2018 page described only in outline.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Basic design and crafts remains the 100-level entry to the technology and design stress area
- Model making, ground plans and build budgeting are the assessed core
- Confirm workshop access rules and whether materials are supplied

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Reading a script for spatial demands

You are given a one-act play set in a compound with three entrances. Here is the analysis order.

1. Highlight every entrance, exit and offstage sound.
2. List every prop that is used, distinguishing hand props, set dressing and furniture.
3. Note every level change and every moment a character must be seen above others.
4. Identify the sightline-critical moment - the one action that must be visible from every seat.
5. Draft the plan with entrances first, furniture second, decoration last.
6. Check the plan against the blocking needs you listed before drawing anything beautiful.

> **What to carry forward**
> Function first: a plan that works can be made beautiful; a beautiful plan that blocks an entrance cannot be used.

2. Choosing a lighting state

The scene moves from a bright afternoon to nightfall in one page. What do you actually change?

1. Decide what the audience must still see: faces, a specific prop, the exits.
2. Choose the direction of the key light to motivate the change - window side cooling and dimming.
3. Keep one constant so the audience reads continuity, such as a practical lamp or a warm back light.
4. Reduce the lit area rather than only reducing brightness; night reads as a smaller pool of light.
5. Check colour temperature consistency between fixtures so faces do not turn two colours.
6. Rehearse the cue with the actors, not only the board operator; a slow fade can change the pacing of the scene.

> **What to carry forward**
> Lighting states are decisions about what the audience may see, not decoration added at the end.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain the purpose of a ground plan, an elevation and a section, and why a design needs all three.

15 marks

1. Ground plan: positions from above to scale, used for blocking and construction.
2. Elevation: vertical face, used for heights and finish.
3. Section: a cut through the set, revealing what the plan hides - sightlines, headroom, construction.
4. Explain the errors each drawing prevents.
5. Conclude that design communication is a set of complementary projections, not one drawing.

Q2. A designer proposes an expensive set that the department cannot build in time. What should happen next?

10 marks

1. Restate the constraint: budget, labour, time and safety are design parameters.
2. Identify the production concept that the set is trying to serve.
3. Propose the cheapest solution that preserves that concept.
4. Document the revised plan with a build schedule and risk notes.
5. Conclude that an unbuildable design is a failed design regardless of its quality on paper.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Blaming the budget. The question is about design judgement under constraint.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Ground plan. A scale drawing of the stage seen from above, showing set, furniture, entrances and the auditorium edge.

Elevation. A scale drawing of a vertical surface of the set, showing height and finish.

Section. A drawing cut through the set vertically, used to check heights, sightlines and construction.

Scale. The ratio between a drawing and reality, for example 1:25 where 4 cm represents 1 m.

Sightline. The line of vision from a seat to the stage; a set must not block the action for any paying seat.

Profile lantern. A lighting fixture producing a controllable hard-edged beam, used for specials and gobos.

Fresnel. A soft-edged wash lantern with an adjustable beam, used for general stage coverage.

Gel. A coloured filter placed in front of a lantern to change the colour of its light.

Practical. A working onstage light source that is visible to the audience, such as a lamp or a fire effect.

Build schedule. The dated plan for constructing, painting and installing a set within the available labour.

Materials list. A quantified list of timber, board, fabric, paint and hardware required, with costs.

Cue. A defined point at which a lighting or sound change is executed.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Script analysis

The brief.

- Mark every entrance, exit and prop in one script.
- List the spatial demands in order of priority.
- Sketch a rough plan without worrying about scale.

Week 2 - Draw

Technical communication.

- Draw a to-scale ground plan.
- Add one elevation and one section.
- Have a coursemate try to read it: if they cannot, label more.

Week 3 - Light and sound

Two departments, one language.

- Learn five fixtures and their uses.
- Write a two-state lighting plot for one scene.
- Plan three sound cues with timings.

Week 4 - Present

The pitch.

- Prepare a five-minute design presentation.
- Include concept, plan, model, materials and budget.
- Take questions and note what you could not answer.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any standard stagecraft text covering ground plans, elevations and construction.
- A lighting design primer for lantern types and colour temperature.
- Your department's workshop safety rules - read these before your first build session.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name the elements and principles of design.

Answer: Elements: line, shape, form, colour, texture, space. Principles: contrast, rhythm, unity, emphasis, pattern, movement, balance, scale.

2. Why is a ground plan essential?

Answer: It shows the arrangement of the stage from above to scale, allowing the director, designer and builder to agree on positions, levels and entrances.

3. What does a 1:25 model mean?

Answer: One unit on the model represents twenty-five of the same units in reality, for example 4 cm equals 1 m.

4. Give two functions of stage lighting.

Answer: Visibility and focus; mood, time of day and shaping the performance space are others.

5. What must accompany a design proposal?

Answer: A concept statement, ground plan, model, materials list, budget and build schedule.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Analyse a script for location, period, entrances and levels.
- [ ] Draw a to-scale ground plan for one scene.
- [ ] Build a simple 1:50 model with a human figure for scale.
- [ ] List materials and costs for your design.
- [ ] Learn five lighting fixtures and their uses.
- [ ] Prepare a five-minute design presentation.
- [ ] Have your tutor review the plan for safety issues.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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